

Materia Medica III

New NCBAHM exam herbs

Ling Zhi (灵芝)

Herbal Category

Herbs that Tonify Qi / Calm the Shen

Latin Name | Common Name

Ganoderma lucidum | Reishi mushroom

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, neutral

Channels Entered: Heart, Lung, Liver

Primary Actions

1. **Tonifies Qi and nourishes Blood**
2. **Calms the Shen**
3. **Stops cough and wheezing**

Key Indications

- Insomnia, palpitations, anxiety from Heart deficiency
- Fatigue and weakness due to Qi deficiency
- Chronic cough or wheezing due to Lung deficiency
- Deficiency-type emotional disturbance

Preparation

Decoction, powder, or medicinal mushroom extract

Dosage

6–12 g in decoction

Cautions / Contraindications

- Generally very safe
- Use caution with anticoagulant therapy

Exam Pearl

One of the few herbs that simultaneously tonifies Qi and calms the Shen.

Clinical Insights

- Particularly useful when Qi deficiency leads to Shen disturbance (fatigue + anxiety + insomnia).
 - Often combined with Suan Zao Ren or Bai Zi Ren for insomnia.
-

Ju Hong (橘红)

Herbal Category

Herbs that Transform Phlegm and Stop Cough

Latin Name | Common Name

Exocarpium Citri Grandis | Red tangerine peel

Nature & Flavor: Acrid, bitter, warm

Channels Entered: Lung, Spleen

Primary Actions

1. **Regulates Qi**
2. **Dries dampness**
3. **Transforms phlegm**
4. **Stops cough**

Key Indications

- Chronic cough with copious sputum
- Damp-phlegm obstructing Lung
- Chest oppression

Preparation

Decoction

Dosage

3–10 g

Cautions / Contraindications

- Use cautiously in Yin deficiency with dryness

Exam Pearl

Stronger at drying damp-phlegm than Chen Pi.

Clinical Insights

Best for phlegm-damp cough with heavy sputum and chest fullness.

Lu Lu Tong (路路通)

Herbal Category

Herbs that Invigorate Blood and Unblock Channels

Latin Name | Common Name

Fructus Liquidambaris | Sweetgum fruit

Nature & Flavor: Bitter, neutral

Channels Entered: Liver, Stomach

Primary Actions

1. **Invigorates blood**
2. **Unblocks channels**
3. **Promotes urination**
4. **Promotes lactation**

Key Indications

- Bi syndrome with pain and stiffness
- Amenorrhea due to blood stagnation
- Edema and dysuria
- Insufficient lactation

Preparation

Decoction

Dosage

5–10 g

Cautions / Contraindications

- Avoid during pregnancy

Exam Pearl

One of the herbs that both invigorates blood and promotes urination.

Clinical Insights

Often used for Bi syndrome with swelling and pain due to damp obstruction.

Chuan Mu Tong (川木通)

Herbal Category

Herbs that Drain Dampness / Promote Urination

Latin Name | Common Name

Caulis Clematidis Armandii | Clematis stem

Nature & Flavor: Bitter, slightly cold

Channels Entered: Heart, Small Intestine, Urinary Bladder

Primary Actions

1. **Promotes urination**
2. **Clears heat from Heart through Small Intestine**
3. **Promotes lactation**

Key Indications

- Painful urinary dysfunction (lin syndrome)
- Heart heat with mouth sores and irritability
- Insufficient lactation

Preparation

Decoction

Dosage

3–6 g

Cautions / Contraindications

- Avoid in pregnancy
- Excessive use may damage kidneys (especially with toxic species)

Exam Pearl

Classic herb for Heart heat transmitted to the Small Intestine, causing urinary symptoms.

Clinical Insights

Used in formulas such as Dao Chi San to drain Heart fire via urination.

Guan Mu Tong (关木通)

Herbal Category

Herbs that Drain Dampness / Promote Urination

Latin Name | Common Name

Aristolochia manshuriensis | Aristolochia stem

Nature & Flavor: Bitter, cold

Channels Entered: Heart, Small Intestine, Urinary Bladder

Primary Actions

1. Promotes urination
2. Drains Heart heat
3. Promotes lactation

Key Indications

- Lin syndrome
- Heart heat with irritability and mouth sores
- Lactation deficiency

Preparation

Decoction

Dosage

3–6 g

Cautions / Contraindications

- Nephrotoxic (aristolochic acid)
- Contraindicated in kidney disease
- Avoid pregnancy

Exam Pearl

Rarely used clinically today due to aristolochic acid toxicity.

Clinical Insights

Modern practice generally substitutes Chuan Mu Tong or Tong Cao for Guan Mu Tong.

Si Gua Luo (丝瓜络)

Herbal Category

Herbs that Unblock Channels and Collaterals

Latin Name | Common Name

Retinervus Luffae Fructus | Loofah sponge

Nature & Flavor: Sweet, neutral

Channels Entered: Liver, Lung, Stomach

Primary Actions

1. **Unblocks channels**
2. **Invigorates blood**
3. **Promotes lactation**
4. **Transforms phlegm**

Key Indications

- Bi syndrome
- Breast disorders with poor lactation
- Chest congestion

Preparation

Decoction

Dosage

5–10 g

Cautions / Contraindications

- Use cautiously during pregnancy

Exam Pearl

Especially useful for breast channel obstruction and mastitis.

Clinical Insights

Often used for postpartum breast pain and insufficient milk.

Zhi Chuan Wu (制川乌)

Herbal Category

Herbs that Dispel Wind-Damp

Latin Name | Common Name

Radix Aconiti Kusnezoffii Preparata | Prepared Sichuan aconite

Nature & Flavor: Acrid, bitter, hot, toxic

Channels Entered: Heart, Liver, Kidney, Spleen

Primary Actions

1. **Dispels wind-damp**
2. **Warms channels**
3. **Stops pain**

Key Indications

- Severe cold-damp Bi syndrome
- Joint pain and numbness

Preparation

Must be properly processed (Zhi)

Dosage

1.5–3 g

Cautions / Contraindications

- Highly toxic if unprocessed
- Avoid pregnancy
- Overdose causes cardiac and neurologic toxicity

Exam Pearl

Stronger pain-relieving effect than Fu Zi but less tonifying.

Clinical Insights

Reserved for severe cold-type Bi with intense pain.

Cao Wu (草乌)

Herbal Category

Herbs that Dispel Wind-Damp

Latin Name | Common Name

Radix Aconiti Kusnezoffii | Wild aconite root

Nature & Flavor: Acrid, bitter, hot, toxic

Channels Entered: Liver, Spleen, Kidney

Primary Actions

1. **Disperses wind-damp**
2. **Warms channels**
3. **Stops pain**

Key Indications

- Severe cold-damp Bi syndrome
- Severe joint pain

Preparation

Must be processed before use

Dosage

1.5–3 g

Cautions / Contraindications

- Extremely toxic
- Contraindicated in pregnancy
- Risk of arrhythmia and neurotoxicity

Exam Pearl

More toxic and stronger than Chuan Wu.

Clinical Insights

Often restricted to external formulas or specialist use.

Summary Comparison

Herb	Key Function
Ling Zhi	Tonifies Qi + calms Shen
Ju Hong	Transforms phlegm-damp cough
Lu Lu Tong	Invigorates blood + unblocks channels
Chuan Mu Tong	Promotes urination + clears Heart heat

Herb	Key Function
Guan Mu Tong	Same actions but nephrotoxic
Si Gua Luo	Unblocks channels + promotes lactation
Zhi Chuan Wu	Strong analgesic for cold-damp Bi
Cao Wu	Even stronger + more toxic aconite